

**Understanding Mental Health Service Utilization and Perceived Need for  
Support Among Undergraduate Students at a Private University in  
Minnesota: A Mixed Methods Study.**

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## **Abstract**

### **Introduction:**

Mental health concerns among college students continue to increase across the United States, yet many students do not use available campus mental health services. This mixed methods study examined mental health service utilization, perceived need for support, and barriers to accessing services among undergraduate students at the University of St. Thomas. A mixed methods cross-sectional design was used. Quantitative data were collected through an anonymous online survey completed by 29 undergraduate students. Qualitative data were collected through semi-structured interviews with 6 undergraduate students. Survey questions examined awareness and utilization of campus mental health services, perceived need for support, and barriers to accessing care. Descriptive statistics and cross-tabulations were analyzed using SPSS, while interview data were analyzed using framework analysis to identify major themes. Most survey participants were female (79.3%), and over half (55.2%) reported needing mental health support within the past 12 months. Although 96.6% of students reported awareness of campus mental health resources, only 27.6% reported using university mental health services. Students who reported needing help were more likely to use campus mental health services than those who did not report needing help. Interview findings identified three major themes: limited awareness and knowledge of services, trust and cultural relevance, and time, stigma, and structural barriers. Integrated findings showed that awareness alone did not guarantee service utilization because students also faced emotional, cultural, and logistical barriers to seeking support. The findings suggest that undergraduate students experience unmet mental health support needs despite awareness of available services. Improving mental health service utilization may require increased outreach, culturally responsive support, reduced stigma, and improved accessibility of campus mental health resources.

## **Plain Language Summary**

Many college students experience stress, anxiety, depression, and other mental health challenges during their academic years. Although colleges often provide counseling and mental health support services, many students do not seek help even when they need it. Barriers such as stigma, lack of awareness, limited trust in counseling services, cultural concerns, and uncertainty about how to access support may prevent students from using available resources.

This study explored how undergraduate students at the University of St. Thomas use campus mental health services and what factors influence their willingness to seek support.

Researchers used both surveys and interviews to better understand students' experiences, awareness of services, and perceived barriers to accessing care.

The findings showed that many students reported needing mental health support within the past year, but fewer students reported using campus mental health services. Students described several challenges that affected help-seeking, including stigma, limited awareness of available services, scheduling difficulties, and concerns about whether counselors would understand their cultural or personal experiences. Interview findings also showed that trust

and feeling understood were important factors influencing students' comfort with seeking help.

These findings suggest that universities should improve awareness of services, reduce stigma, and provide more accessible and culturally supportive mental health resources to better support student well-being.

## **Introduction**

Mental health concerns among college students have become an increasingly important public health issue in the United States. Anxiety disorders are among the most common psychiatric concerns among college students, affecting approximately 11.9% of students, while depression prevalence rates range from 7% to 9% (Pedrelli et al., 2014). In addition, a national survey of college students reported that 6.7% of students experienced suicidal ideation within the previous year (Pedrelli et al., 2014). Since the COVID-19 pandemic, studies have continued to show increasing levels of stress, anxiety, depression, and emotional distress among undergraduate students (Campbell et al., 2022). These mental health concerns negatively affect academic performance, social relationships, sleep quality, and overall well-being among college students (Osborn et al., 2022). College students often experience multiple stressors, including academic pressure, financial challenges, social adjustment, and the transition to independent living, all of which contribute to poorer mental health outcomes (Campbell et al., 2022).

In response to growing mental health concerns, many colleges and universities have expanded counseling and psychological support services. However, the availability of services does not always guarantee student utilization. Access to mental health services includes awareness of available resources, perceived ease of access, cultural responsiveness, affordability, and reduced stigma associated with seeking help (Cha et al., 2019). Previous research has shown that many students experiencing elevated stress or emotional distress do not seek professional support even when services are available (Fortney et al., 2017; Zhao et al., 2025). Students frequently encounter barriers to mental health treatment, including stigma, lack of awareness, scheduling difficulties, concerns about confidentiality, and uncertainty regarding how to access support services (Weissinger et al., 2024; Lattie et al., 2019). Research also suggests that improving accessibility and student engagement with mental health resources may improve psychological well-being among college students (Lattie et al., 2019).

Existing research on college student mental health has primarily focused on anxiety, depression, and help-seeking behaviours at large public universities across the United States. While several studies have examined barriers to counselling access and mental health service utilization, fewer studies have explored how perceived access to campus mental health resources relates specifically to perceived stress among students attending smaller private universities in the Midwest. In addition, limited research has focused on how undergraduate students perceive the effectiveness and accessibility of campus mental health resources during their transition into college life. Understanding this relationship is important because students who perceive mental health services as inaccessible or unhelpful may experience higher levels of stress and reduced overall well-being.

At the University of St. Thomas, undergraduate students may experience stress related to academic adjustment, financial responsibilities, social transition, and balancing multiple obligations. Research has shown that first-generation college students and students adjusting to university life may experience heightened stress, anxiety, and depression during transitional periods in college (Rockwell & Kimel, 2025). Although campus mental health resources are available at the University of St. Thomas, little is known about how students perceive access to these services and whether perceived access is associated with levels of stress among undergraduate students. Examining these perceptions may provide important insight into barriers and facilitators that influence mental health service utilization within the university setting.

Therefore, the purpose of this study is to examine the relationship between access to mental health resources and perceived stress among undergraduate students at the University of St. Thomas during the 2024-2025 academic year. Specifically, this study asks: Among undergraduate students at the University of St. Thomas, how is access to mental health resources on campus associated with perceived stress during the 2024-2025 academic year? Findings from this study may contribute to a better understanding of how universities can improve mental health support systems and better address student well-being among undergraduate students.

## **Methods**

### **Study Design**

This study used a convergent mixed-methods design to examine the relationship between access to mental health resources and perceived stress among undergraduate students at the University of St. Thomas (UST). A mixed-methods approach was selected to provide a more comprehensive understanding of students' experiences by combining quantitative survey data with qualitative interview data. Quantitative data were used to identify patterns in awareness, utilization, and perceived barriers to mental health services, while qualitative interviews provided deeper insight into students' personal experiences, perceptions, and attitudes regarding mental health support. The integration of both methods allowed the researchers to better understand how access to mental health resources may influence perceived stress among undergraduate students.

### **Study Population and Setting**

The study was conducted at the University of St. Thomas, a private university located in St. Paul and Minneapolis, Minnesota. UST enrolls undergraduate students from diverse academic, cultural, and socioeconomic backgrounds. The study population included undergraduate students currently enrolled at UST who were 18 years of age or older. Both traditional and nontraditional undergraduate students were eligible to participate. Recruitment focused primarily on undergraduate students because college students often experience stress related to academic demands, financial pressures, social adjustment, and transitions into adulthood. Understanding access to campus mental health resources within this population

was important for evaluating whether available services adequately support student well-being.

## **Sampling and Recruitment**

Participants were recruited using convenience sampling. The survey link was distributed through student group chats, university email communication, and social media platforms commonly used by students. Flyers containing a QR code linked to the survey were also shared to increase participation. Participation was voluntary, and no incentives were provided. Students who met the eligibility criteria and agreed to participate completed the anonymous online survey. In addition to survey recruitment, undergraduate students were invited to participate in semi-structured interviews to provide more detailed perspectives regarding their experiences with mental health resources and perceived stress.

## **Data Collection Methods**

***Quantitative:*** Data were collected using an anonymous online survey created in Qualtrics. Before beginning the survey, participants reviewed an electronic informed consent form and indicated their agreement to participate. The survey took approximately 10 minutes to complete. Survey questions included demographic information such as age, gender, and school year, as well as questions related to awareness of campus mental health resources, utilization of services such as the Center for Well-Being, perceived barriers to accessing services, and perceived stress levels. Most survey questions used multiple-choice and Likert-scale response options, along with one open-ended question to allow participants to describe additional experiences or concerns.

***Qualitative:*** Data were collected through semi-structured interviews conducted with undergraduate students. Interviews explored students' awareness of available mental health services, experiences accessing support, perceived barriers to care, cultural influences, stigma, trust in counseling services, and the relationship between mental health support and stress management. Interviews allowed participants to provide detailed descriptions of their experiences and perspectives beyond the information collected in the survey.

## **Variables and Measures**

The primary outcome variable in this study was utilization of campus mental health services, specifically whether students had used mental health resources such as the Center for Well-Being. Key exposure variables included awareness of mental health resources, perceived accessibility of services, trust in counselling services, cultural relevance, and perceived barriers to seeking support, including stigma, limited time, scheduling difficulties, and lack of knowledge about available resources. Perceived stress was also examined as an important variable associated with access to mental health resources. Demographic variables including age, gender, and school year were analysed descriptively to better understand participant characteristics.

## **Data Analysis**

Quantitative survey data were analyzed using IBM SPSS Statistics. Descriptive statistics, including frequencies, percentages, and summary measures, were used to describe participant demographics, awareness of mental health resources, utilization of services, and perceived barriers to care. Crosstab analyses were conducted to examine relationships between utilization of mental health services and factors such as awareness of resources, perceived barriers, and stress-related experiences. Tables and figures were used to summarize survey findings.

Qualitative interview data were analysed using framework analysis. Interview responses were reviewed multiple times to identify recurring ideas and meaningful patterns related to access to mental health resources and perceived stress. Initial codes were developed from participant responses and organized into broader themes. Themes identified across interviews included limited awareness of available resources, trust and cultural relevance in counselling services, and structural barriers such as stigma, time limitations, and scheduling difficulties. The research team compared and discussed codes and themes to improve consistency and interpretation of findings.

Following separate quantitative and qualitative analyses, findings from both methods were integrated using a joint display approach. Integration allowed the researchers to compare survey findings with interview themes and identify areas where both methods supported or expanded upon one another. This mixed-methods integration provided a more complete understanding of how access to mental health resources influences stress experiences among undergraduate students at UST.

## **Ethical Considerations**

This study was conducted as part of PUBH 465 at the University of St. Thomas under the supervision of Professor Deanna Tollefson. The study was exempt from full IRB review. Participation was voluntary, and participants were informed that they could skip questions or stop participation at any time without penalty. No identifying information was collected in the survey or interviews.

## **Results**

This mixed methods study examined how access to mental health services relates to perceived stress and help seeking among undergraduate students at the University of St. Thomas.

### **Participant Characteristics**

A total of 29 undergraduate students participated in the survey and 6 students participated in semi-structured interviews. Most participants were female (79.3%) and 20.7% were male. Participants were distributed across class years, with juniors representing the largest group (37.9%), followed by sophomores and seniors (31.0% each). The majority identified as Black or African American (48.3%) or White (41.4%), with smaller proportions identifying as Hispanic or Latino (6.9%) or preferring not to say (3.4%).

### **Survey Results**

More than half of participants (55.2%) reported needing mental health help in the past 12 months. Despite this, only 27.6% reported using University of St. Thomas mental health services, while 72.4% did not use services. Most participants (96.6%) reported being aware of available campus mental health services. In terms of help-seeking behavior, 51.7% of participants reported being likely to seek help, while 48.3% reported neutral or unlikely responses. Additionally, 58.6% reported having visited UST wellbeing services, compared to 41.4% who had not.

Table 3 shows differences in service use based on reported need for help. Among students who used mental health services, 75.0% reported needing help in the past 12 months, compared to 47.6% among those who did not use services. In contrast, 52.4% of students who did not use services reported they did not need help.

Figure 1 supports this pattern, showing higher percentages of service use among students who reported needing help compared to those who did not need help or were unsure. Figure 2 The most commonly reported barriers included preference to handle issues independently, time constraints, and belief that services would not help.

## **Interview Results**

Across all interviews, three main themes emerged that help explain how access to mental health services relates to students' perceived stress and help seeking.

### **Theme 1: Limited awareness and unclear knowledge of services**

Students described limited understanding of available mental health services beyond initial exposure during orientation.

*"I did not even know we had mental health services. It was mentioned briefly during orientation, and then I never heard about it again."*

Students who had less awareness were less likely to seek help and often reported feeling unsure about where to go or how to start.

### **Theme 2: Trust, cultural relevance, and feeling understood**

Students emphasized that feeling understood and culturally supported influenced their willingness to seek help.

*"I feel like it would be more difficult for them to understand culturally and religiously what I am going through."*

Concerns about whether counsellors would understand their identity or background reduced comfort in using services.

### **Theme 3: Time, stigma, and structural barriers**

Students described practical and social barriers that made it difficult to access services even when they needed help.

*“I think time is a big one, and just not knowing how to start. Stigma is still a barrier.”*

Busy schedules, difficulty booking appointments, and fear of judgment reduced help-seeking behavior.

## Integration of Results

Survey and interview findings together provide a clearer understanding of student mental health service use.

High reported need for help (55.2%) aligns with interview descriptions of stress from academic pressure and daily responsibilities. However, low service use (27.6%) is explained by barriers such as limited awareness, stigma, and time constraints. Although awareness of services was high (96.6%), interviews showed that students often lacked clear knowledge of how to access services, which limited actual use. Similarly, while over half of students reported being likely to seek help, interview findings showed that trust, cultural relevance, and comfort strongly influenced whether students followed through.

Overall, combining survey and interview findings shows that access to mental health services is influenced not only by availability, but also by awareness, trust, and structural barriers.

Table 1. Demographics and Participant characteristics (N=29)

| Demographic            | n (%)    |
|------------------------|----------|
| <b>Gender</b>          |          |
| Male                   | 6 (20.7) |
| Female                 | 23(79.3) |
| <b>Age: mean (SD)</b>  |          |
| 19                     | 3(10.3)  |
| 20                     | 7(24.1)  |
| 21                     | 13(44.8) |
| 22                     | 5(17.2)  |
| 23                     | 1(3.4)   |
| <b>Year in school</b>  |          |
| Sophomore              | 9(31.0)  |
| Junior                 | 11(37.9) |
| Senior                 | 9(31.0)  |
| <b>Race</b>            |          |
| Black/African American | 14(48.3) |
| White                  | 12(41.4) |
| Hispanic/Latino        | 2(6.9)   |
| Prefer not to say      | 1(3.4)   |

Table 2: Mental Health Service Utilization and Awareness (N=29)

| <b>Variable</b>                         | <b>n (%)</b> |
|-----------------------------------------|--------------|
| <b>Needed help in past 12 months</b>    |              |
| Yes                                     | 16(55.2)     |
| No/Not sure                             | 13(44.8)     |
| <b>Used UST mental health services</b>  |              |
| Yes                                     | 8(27.6)      |
| No                                      | 21(72.4)     |
| <b>Awareness of UST mental services</b> |              |
| Aware (any level)                       | 28(96.6)     |
| Not aware                               | 1(3.4)       |
| Likelihood of seeking help              |              |
| Likely (somewhat/extremely)             | 15(51.7)     |
| Neutral/ Unlikely                       | 14(48.3)     |
| <b>Visited UST wellbeing services</b>   |              |
| Yes                                     | 17(58.6)     |
| No                                      | 12(41.4)     |
| <b>Likelihood of seeking help</b>       |              |
| Somewhat likely                         | 8(27.6)      |
| Extremely likely                        | 7(24.1)      |
| Neither likely nor unlikely             | 5(17.2)      |
| Somewhat unlikely                       | 2(6.9)       |
| Other response/barrier                  | 7(24.1)      |

Table 3. UST Mental Health Services Use by Need for Help (N=29)

| <b>Used UST MH services</b> | <b>Needed help n (%)</b> | <b>Did not need help n (%)</b> | <b>Total</b> |
|-----------------------------|--------------------------|--------------------------------|--------------|
| Yes                         | 6(75.0)                  | 2(25.0)                        | 8(100)       |

|    |          |          |         |
|----|----------|----------|---------|
| No | 10(47.6) | 11(52.4) | 21(100) |
|----|----------|----------|---------|

Figure 1. Reported use of UST Mental Health Service by Need for Help

GGraph

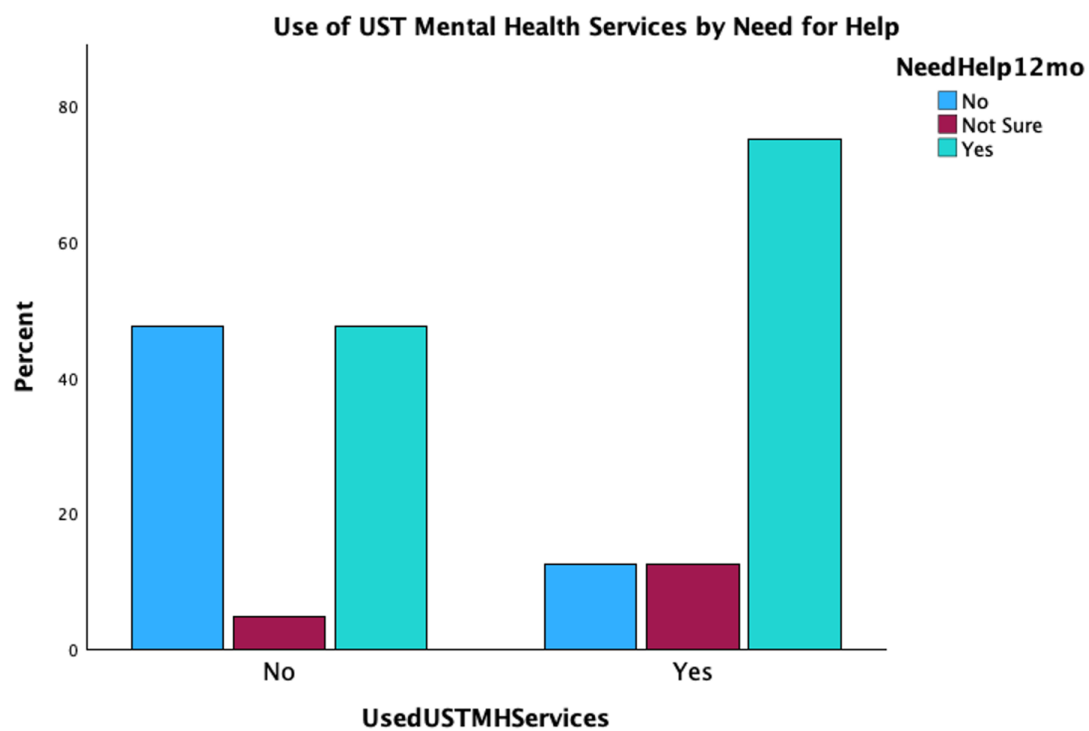
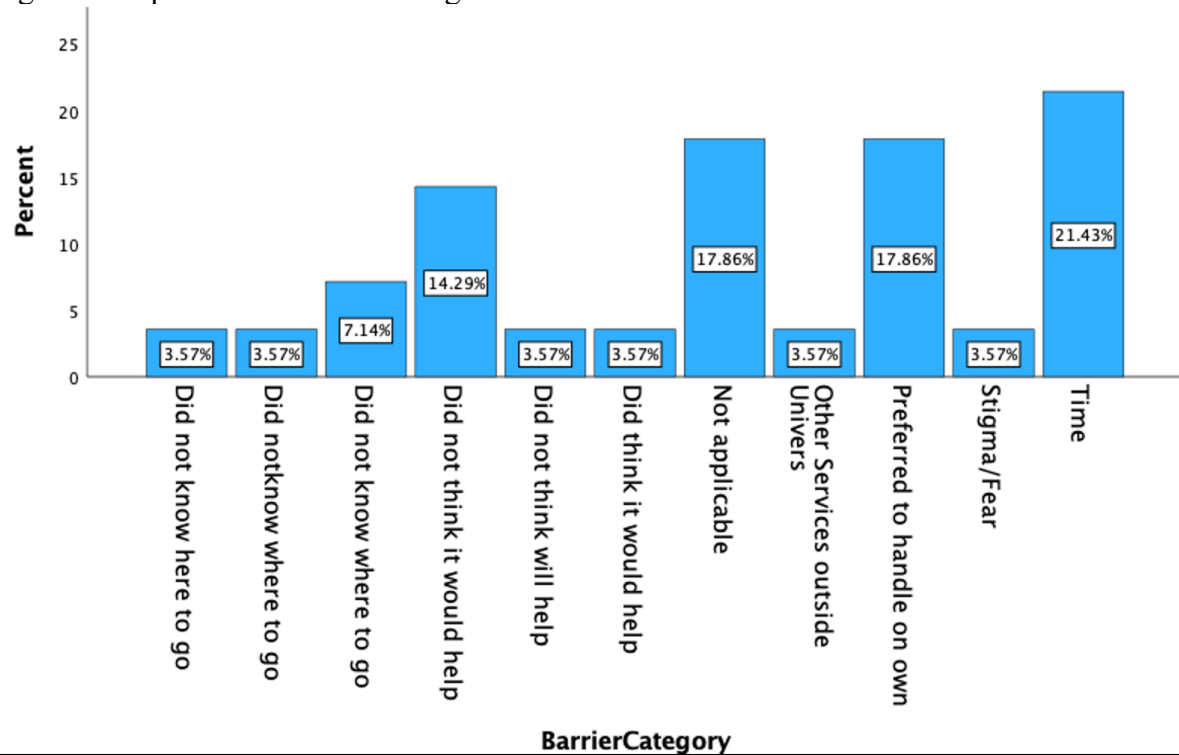


Figure 2. Reported Barriers to Using UST Mental Health Services



The most commonly reported barriers included preference to handle issues independently, time constraints, and belief that services would not help.

Table 4: Joint Display of Survey and Interview Findings on Mental Health Services Use

| Topic                | Survey Findings                               | Interview Findings                                        | Integrated Insight                                           |
|----------------------|-----------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------|
| Need for help        | 55.2% reported needing help in past 12 months | Students described stress, anxiety, and academic pressure | High need is supported by personal experiences               |
| Use of services      | 27.6% used UST services                       | Some students avoided services due to stigma or time      | Low usage may be linked to barriers identified in interviews |
| Awareness            | Mixed awareness of services                   | Some students did not know where to go                    | Lack of awareness affects service use                        |
| Comfort seeking help | Many reported neutral to somewhat comfortable | Students preferred informal support first                 | Comfort level influences whether students seek formal help   |

The joint display table integrated quantitative survey findings with qualitative interview themes to provide a more complete understanding of mental health service utilization among UST undergraduate students. Survey findings showed that many students reported needing mental health support, while a smaller proportion reported using university mental health services. Interview findings helped explain this gap by identifying barriers related to limited awareness of services, concerns about trust and cultural understanding, stigma, and time

constraints. Students who felt more informed and supported were more likely to describe positive attitudes toward seeking help, while those who experienced uncertainty, discomfort, or structural barriers were less likely to access services. Together, the integrated findings suggest that improving awareness, accessibility, and culturally responsive support services may help increase mental health service utilization among undergraduate students at the University of St. Thomas.

## **Discussion**

### **Main Findings**

This mixed methods study examined how access to mental health resources at the University of St. Thomas is associated with students' perceived need for support. The findings show that more than half of participants reported needing mental health help in the past 12 months, yet most students had not used UST mental health services. Students who reported using services also reported higher levels of need, which suggests that help-seeking often occurs after distress increases rather than early. At the same time, awareness of resources such as the UST wellbeing page was moderate but did not lead to higher utilization. These findings suggest that access to mental health services alone is not sufficient to meet student needs due to gaps in awareness, trust, and actual use.

### **Comparison With existing Literature**

These findings are consistent with previous research showing that college students report high levels of mental health need but low utilization of services (Fortney et al., 2017; Osborn et al., 2022). Prior studies have also identified stigma, lack of awareness, and structural barriers as key factors influencing help-seeking behavior (Zhao et al., 2025). This study adds to the existing literature by focusing on students at the University of St. Thomas and by using a mixed methods approach to provide a more complete understanding of these barriers. By combining quantitative and qualitative data, this study not only identifies patterns in service use but also explains the underlying reasons for those patterns.

The integration of survey and interview findings strengthens these results. Survey data identified a gap between need and service use, while interview findings explained why this gap exists. Students described limited awareness of services beyond initial orientation, uncertainty about how to access care, and difficulty navigating available resources. In addition, themes of trust and cultural relevance influenced whether students felt comfortable seeking help. Many participants expressed a desire for providers who understand their cultural and personal experiences. Barriers such as stigma, time constraints, and lack of clear guidance further limited service use. These findings align with prior research showing that psychosocial barriers, including stigma and lack of knowledge, reduce mental health service utilization among college students (Cha et al., 2019; Weissinger et al., 2024).

### **Public Health Implications**

The findings have important public health implications. Universities should improve how mental health services are introduced and promoted to students beyond initial orientation. Efforts to increase awareness, reduce stigma, and improve cultural competence among providers may increase service utilization. Addressing these barriers may support earlier help-seeking and improve overall student mental health outcomes.

## **Strengths and Limitations**

This study has several strengths. The mixed methods design allowed for a more comprehensive understanding of mental health service use by combining survey data with interview insights. This approach strengthens the validity of the findings by providing both measurable trends and contextual explanations. However, there are limitations to consider. The sample size was small and limited to one university, which limits generalizability. The cross-sectional design prevents conclusions about causality between access and perceived need. In addition, the use of self-reported data may introduce response bias. Despite these limitations, steps were taken to ensure consistency in data collection and analysis, which supports the reliability of the findings.

## **Recommendations**

Future research should examine larger and more diverse student populations to better understand patterns in mental health service use. Studies should also evaluate specific interventions aimed at improving awareness, reducing stigma, and increasing trust in campus mental health services. A key takeaway from this study is that improving access to mental health services requires more than availability. Universities must address awareness, trust, and cultural relevance to better support student mental health.

## **Conclusion**

This study highlights the importance of improving awareness, accessibility, trust, and cultural responsiveness in campus mental health services among undergraduate students at the university of St. Thomas. Although many students reported needing mental health support, fewer students utilized available campus resources. Survey and interview findings showed barriers such as stigma, limited awareness of services, uncertainty about how to access support, and concerns about cultural understanding. Influenced help-seeking behaviors. Improving outreach efforts, reducing structural barriers, and strengthening culturally responsive support services may help universities better address student mental health needs and promote overall student well-being.

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